The Negro Speaks of Rivers

Langston Hughes · 1921

Source: Langston Hughes, "The Negro Speaks of Rivers," first published in The Crisis, June 1921. Public domain (published before 1929). Complete text.

> Written when Hughes was seventeen, this landmark poem of the Harlem Renaissance links the depth of Black identity and history to the world's great rivers — from the Euphrates and Nile to the Mississippi.

COMPLETE TEXT — UNEDITED

I've known rivers:

I've known rivers ancient as the world and older than the flow of human blood in human veins.

My soul has grown deep like the rivers.

I bathed in the Euphrates when dawns were young.

I built my hut near the Congo and it lulled me to sleep.

I looked upon the Nile and raised the pyramids above it.

I heard the singing of the Mississippi when Abe Lincoln went down to New Orleans, and I've seen its muddy bosom turn all golden in the sunset.

I've known rivers:

Ancient, dusky rivers.

My soul has grown deep like the rivers.